

One Algorithm, Two Responses: Occupational Identity and Motivation in White and Blue Collar Platform Work

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Abstract

Purpose: This paper proposes the Occupational-Motivational Engagement Model (OMEM), a conceptual framework for thinking about how occupational identity shapes motivational experience under algorithmic management on digital work platforms.

Design/methodology/approach: The paper is conceptual. It draws on integrative theorising, bringing together Self-Determination Theory, Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory, and occupational identity research, and reading these alongside contemporary work-design scholarship (Parker & Knight, 2024) and recent empirical evidence from platform-work studies. Following a problematisation logic, we identify a gap in current frameworks and propose three psychological mechanisms (identity-based need prioritisation, cognitive framing of platform features, and occupation-specific social comparison) that, acting together, produce systematic differences in how white-collar and blue-collar platform workers experience algorithmic management.

Findings: Seven propositions set out the occupational differences. White-collar workers tend to prioritise method autonomy, read algorithmic control as an encroachment on professional discretion, and anchor their comparisons on skill development and client quality. Blue-collar workers tend to prioritise temporal autonomy, treat algorithms as a source of predictability, and compare on earnings and performance metrics.

Practical implications: OMEM points HRM toward occupationally informed algorithmic design. Platforms should protect method autonomy and invest in qualitative feedback for white-collar workers. For blue-collar workers, predictable workflows and legible quantitative metrics matter more. *Originality/value:* OMEM is, to our knowledge, the first mechanism-based framework that connects occupational identity, algorithmic job

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design, and motivational outcomes in digital labour. It responds to gaps flagged in recent systematic reviews of platform work (Kadolkar et al., 2024; Masta & Kaushiva, 2024) by explaining why workers from different occupational backgrounds read the same algorithmic management differently, and offers a theoretical base for occupationally sensitive HRM design.

Keywords: Digital platform work; Algorithmic management; Occupational identity; Worker motivation; Job design; Self-Determination Theory

1. INTRODUCTION

In January 2026, gig workers across India staged their first coordinated nationwide protest. They demanded dignity, algorithmic transparency, and accountable platform governance (The Hindu, 2026). Days later, the Economic Survey 2025–26 reported that the

Country's gig workforce had grown from 7.7 million in FY2020–21 to roughly 12 million in FY2024–25, a 55 per cent rise in four years, and called explicitly for policy to rein in platform power, regulate algorithmic decision-making, and close the cost gap between gig work and conventional employment (Government of India, 2026). Draft rules released the same month under the Code on Social Security proposed a 90-day engagement threshold for benefit eligibility (Ministry of Labour & Employment, 2026). The pattern is hard to miss. Algorithmic management is no longer studied as a glimpse of the future. It is already a mainstream HRM phenomenon with real policy consequences.

So far, the policy and managerial response has tended to treat platform workers as a single category. Recent scholarship does not support that assumption. Lu et al. (2026) find that workers' experience of algorithmic reliability shapes trust and engagement in different ways depending on occupational stigma consciousness. Nagre et al. (2025) and Kaur and Verma (2025) show that expectations, recognition, and employer signals translate unevenly into affective commitment across worker profiles. The harder question is why. What psychological machinery leads a freelance designer and a food-delivery rider to read the same algorithmic feature so differently? Without a mechanism-based account, HRM risks designing features that motivate one occupational group while quietly flattening another.

Digital platform work is often described as offering autonomy, flexibility, and opportunities for skill development, but workers do not experience these features uniformly (Jarrahi et al., 2020; Kurian & Madhavi, 2024). Responses diverge across occupational groups. White-collar workers often expect method autonomy, professional discretion,

and opportunities for competence development. Blue-collar workers tend to place greater weight on temporal autonomy, earnings stability, and performance-based feedback. Algorithmic management can both enable and constrain these expectations, since it structures work in ways that influence discretion, predictability, and opportunities for growth (Wood et al., 2018; Möhlmann et al., 2021).

Two recent systematic reviews have mapped the terrain. Masta and Kaushiva (2024) reviewed 258 gig-economy studies and identified algorithmic management as a major site of scholarly attention, while noting that comparative research across worker profiles remains thin. A parallel review by Kadolkar et al. (2024), reading algorithmic management through an organisational behaviour lens, reaches a similar conclusion: the field has grown rapidly, but there is still a gap in explaining the mechanisms through which particular dimensions of algorithmic management affect gig-worker outcomes. This is precisely the gap OMEM is designed to fill. If HRM cannot explain why workers respond differently to algorithmic systems, it will continue to ship features that suit some occupational groups and quietly undermine motivation in others.

Theoretical work within HRM has not caught up. HR systems research has historically focused on organisational-level outcomes, but recent reviews point to the need for closer attention to individual-level variation and to the occupational differences that shape how HR practices are experienced (Boon et al., 2019). The literature already establishes that individual differences moderate job design effects (Truxillo et al., 2012). What remains underdeveloped is the specific role of occupational identity in shaping how platform workers interpret algorithmically managed work. Existing studies describe autonomy, algorithmic control, and platform job characteristics well enough, but they say less about the psychological mechanisms that differentiate workers' interpretations along occupational lines (Gandini, 2018; Duggan et al., 2023). Digital labour is also, increasingly, an early-career entry point. The absence of a mechanism-based account limits what we can say about how platform work shapes identity formation, motivation, and engagement.

The Occupational-Motivational Engagement Model (OMEM) is an attempt to address this. It is a theoretical framework in which occupational identity moderates motivational processes in digital platform work. The model responds to calls for comparative research across worker profiles (Kadolkar et al., 2024; Masta & Kaushiva, 2024) and builds on recent evidence that psychological needs remain salient for gig workers across settings (Lu et al., 2026; Nagre et al., 2025) and

that worker engagement shapes retention outcomes (Kaur & Verma, 2025). OMEM integrates Self-Determination Theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000), Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory (Herzberg et al., 1959), and occupational identity scholarship (Lips-Wiersma et al., 2016). It argues that workers' interpretations of digital work features are shaped by three mechanisms: identity-based need prioritisation, cognitive framing of platform features, and social comparison reference groups. These mechanisms do not operate in isolation. They combine to produce the occupationally distinct motivational patterns OMEM seeks to explain.

By articulating these processes, OMEM connects digital job design, algorithmic HRM, and occupational identity development. It also offers practical guidance for designing technology-mediated work systems that serve diverse occupational groups rather than a single stylized worker. The remainder of the paper develops the theoretical foundations, the conceptual approach, and the framework itself.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

OMEM rests on three bodies of scholarship: algorithmic management in platform work, Self-Determination Theory and worker motivation, and occupational identity and work design. We review each in turn and flag the specific gap the framework addresses.

1. **Algorithmic Management in Platform Work:** Digital platform work introduces a distinct technological architecture — algorithmic monitoring, automated task allocation, digital performance metrics, and technology-mediated communication — that reshapes how workers read job characteristics, build identities, and experience motivation. Platform workers rely on algorithmic cues, digital dashboards, and dispersed online communities to make sense of what they do (Rosso et al., 2010; Petriglieri et al., 2018). Oldham and Hackman (2010) observe that contemporary organisational work is increasingly characterised by fluid relationships rather than fixed jobs, with substantial implications for how job design is studied. Platform work is the clearest expression of this shift. Workers manage multiple activities in parallel, serve temporary clients, and operate as independent contractors.

Duggan et al. (2023) describe this phenomenon as “algorithmic HRM control”. In their account, app-based gig work is distinctive both in the pervasiveness of algorithmic enactment and in the direct influence of non-organisational parties, such as clients and customers, on worker control. This double displacement of supervisory authority raises fresh questions

about how workers interpret and respond to platform design. Building on this view, Kadolkar et al. (2024) provide a systematic review integrating algorithmic management research through an organisational behaviour lens. They document rapid scholarly growth but note that the mechanisms through which specific dimensions of algorithmic management translate into worker outcomes remain fragmented and under-theorised. Work-design research identifies several categories of work characteristics — stimulating, mastery-oriented, autonomous, relational, and tolerable — that influence motivation through distinct psychological mechanisms (Parker & Knight, 2024). How occupational identity moderates workers' responses to these characteristics in platform contexts is a much less developed question.

2. **Self-Determination Theory and Worker Motivation:** Self-Determination Theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000) proposes that autonomy, competence, and relatedness are universal psychological needs, and that their satisfaction underpins intrinsic motivation and sustained engagement. Recent theoretical work has extended SDT to contemporary and technology-mediated contexts, treating self-determination as a useful unifying lens for the future of work (Gagné et al., 2022; Deci et al., 2017). Empirical applications to platform and gig contexts indicate that these needs remain salient even where traditional employment relationships are absent: fairness, recognition, and transparency matter for gig worker engagement (Nagre et al., 2025), and experienced algorithmic reliability shapes platform trust and engagement, with occupational factors moderating the effect (Lu et al., 2026). What SDT's standard formulation does not resolve is which subdimensions of each need become psychologically central for different workers. This is a question OMEM addresses by introducing occupational identity as a moderator.
3. **Occupational Identity and Digital Work Design:** Professional identity formation involves ongoing self-evaluation, experimentation, and the integration of work experience into one's occupational self-concept (Ibarra, 1999; Pratt et al., 2006). Early-career stages are now increasingly lived out in digital labour markets. Platforms allow workers to sample tasks, interact with diverse clients, and acquire skills across flexible engagements, but they lack the traditional socialisation infrastructure of colleagues, supervisors, mentors, and structured developmental pathways. Identity formation therefore leans more heavily on algorithmic signals (ratings,

performance data), digital community norms, and workers' interpretations of platform structures (Van Zoonen et al., 2023; Reissner & Armitage-Chan, 2024).

Occupational psychology shows that occupational groups differ systematically in how they value autonomy, skill development, income stability, and relational experiences. White-collar workers often prioritise creativity, method autonomy, and professional growth. Blue-collar workers tend to emphasise predictability, temporal autonomy, and feedback-reinforced competence (Lips-Wiersma et al., 2016). Traditional job-design research has focused primarily on individual motivational attributes. Oldham and Hackman (2010) acknowledge that their Job Characteristics Theory paid insufficient attention to broader contextual factors and to the social dimensions of work, a gap that matters especially for platform work, where social interaction has become increasingly prominent. Research further shows that worker characteristics moderate job-design effects (Truxillo et al., 2012; Cangialosi et al., 2023). Occupational identity — the schemas, values, and self-concepts associated with one's occupational category — is a distinct moderator that shapes how workers read platform features. Algorithmic task allocation may feel restrictive to a white-collar worker who expects discretion but useful to a blue-collar worker who values efficiency. Structured workflows may blunt intrinsic motivation for one group while strengthening competence perceptions for the other (Lehdonvirta, 2018; Wood et al., 2018).

4. **Research Gap:** Reading these three literatures together produces a clear and under-addressed gap. Platform work is now a mainstream mode of labour (Government of India, 2026; Masta & Kaushiva, 2024). Algorithmic management is well documented, but the mechanisms through which algorithmic features produce divergent motivational outcomes are under-theorised (Kadolkar et al., 2024). SDT provides a universal account of psychological needs but does not specify which subdimensions matter most for different workers. Occupational identity research establishes that occupational groups differ in what they value from work, yet it has not been systematically integrated with algorithmic job-design theory. OMEM addresses this gap by theorising occupational identity as the lens through which workers interpret platform features, evaluate algorithmic decisions, and construct meaning from digital work.

3. CONCEPTUAL APPROACH AND METHODOLOGY

1. **Paper Classification:** This is a conceptual paper. Conceptual research develops novel theoretical frameworks by integrating ideas from existing literatures rather than by analysing primary empirical data (Gilson & Goldberg, 2015; Jaakkola, 2020). Following Cornelissen (2017), we treat theory-building as a distinct scholarly contribution, guided by coherence, parsimony, and the generation of testable propositions.
2. **Theorising Strategy:** We adopt an integrative theorising strategy (MacInnis, 2011). The core move is to bring previously disconnected bodies of knowledge into contact in a way that produces novel explanation. OMEM integrates four theoretical streams: Self-Determination Theory as a universal account of psychological needs (Ryan & Deci, 2000; Gagné et al., 2022), Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory as a lens on motivators and hygiene factors (Herzberg et al., 1959), contemporary work-design scholarship in the SMART tradition (Parker & Knight, 2024), and occupational identity research (Skorikov & Vondracek, 2011; Lips-Wiersma et al., 2016).
3. **Literature Selection:** The literatures reviewed were identified through a structured search in Scopus, Web of Science, and Google Scholar. Search terms included "platform work", "gig economy", "algorithmic management", "occupational identity", "job design", "self-determination theory", and "social comparison". We prioritized high-quality peer-reviewed journals in HRM and organizational behavior, articles published between 2018 and 2026 (reflecting the rapid evolution of the field), and foundational theoretical works where they anchor a named theory used in the framework.
4. **Identifying the Research Gap:** Rather than positioning OMEM as an incremental extension of an existing framework, we surface and challenge an in-house assumption in platform-work research: those platform workers are a homogeneous category. The framework is built around the alternative assumption that occupational identity is a primary source of heterogeneity in motivational response.
5. **Framework Development and Proposition Generation:** Integration proceeded in three stages. First, we mapped points of theoretical overlap across the source literatures. Second, we identified three psychological mechanisms through which occupational identity plausibly moderates motivational outcomes: need prioritization, cognitive framing, and social comparison. Third, we translated each mechanism into testable

propositions. The seven propositions presented in Section 5 are intended to guide subsequent empirical work rather than to describe observed findings.

4. FRAMEWORK DEVELOPMENT: THE OCCUPATIONAL-MOTIVATIONAL ENGAGEMENT MODEL

The Occupational-Motivational Engagement Model (OMEM) explains how workers' occupational identities shape their motivational experiences within technology-mediated work environments. It integrates Self-Determination Theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000), Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory (Herzberg et al., 1959), contemporary work-design scholarship (Parker & Knight, 2024), and occupational identity research (Skorikov & Vondracek, 2011). Occupational identity is positioned as the lens through which workers interpret platform features, evaluate algorithmic decisions, and construct meaning from digital work.

Digital labour environments are structured by algorithmic systems that allocate tasks, monitor performance, present feedback, and set the rules for worker-client interaction. Workers do not respond uniformly to these structures. Motivations vary based on individual characteristics and on how workers interpret platform affordances and constraints (Möhlmann et al., 2021; Jarrahi et al., 2020; Truxillo et al., 2012; Lu et al., 2026). OMEM builds on this insight by theorising that occupational schemas moderate how workers perceive autonomy, competence, and relatedness under algorithmic management.

Parker and Knight (2024) identify five universal categories of work-design characteristics in their SMART model: Stimulating, Mastery, Autonomous, Relational, and Tolerable. Each links to psychological outcomes through distinct mechanisms. Their framework shows that work characteristics serve a dual function, both as organisational design decisions and as psychological resources for workers. In platform contexts, algorithmic systems define these characteristics (task variety, feedback quality, autonomy levels, social interaction opportunities). OMEM argues that occupational identity fundamentally moderates how workers experience and respond to each SMART category. Where SMART establishes what work characteristics matter universally, OMEM explains why and how they matter differently across occupational groups.

Boon et al. (2019) distinguish, in their systematic review, between intended HR systems (organisational design), implemented practices (manager delivery), and employee perceptions, emphasising that the same HR system can carry very different meanings at different levels. In platform work, this distinction becomes critical. Algorithmic

systems create particular challenges for alignment between intended design and worker perception, with occupational identity serving as a key lens through which workers interpret platform features. Three interconnected psychological mechanisms are proposed:

1. **Identity-based need prioritization:** Occupational identities influence the relative importance workers place on autonomy, competence, and relatedness, and thus determine which SMART categories become psychologically central.
2. **Cognitive framing of platform features:** Occupational schemas affect how workers interpret algorithmic decisions, task structures, and digital feedback systems. The same platform feature can receive different evaluations depending on occupational identity.
3. **Social comparison reference groups:** Occupational identity shapes who workers compare themselves with and which performance indicators they use, which in turn moderates the motivational impact of platform-generated comparison information.

These mechanisms operate simultaneously. They become especially salient during early-career stages, when identity development is fluid and work experiences play a formative role (Ibarra, 1999). By articulating these identity-driven processes, OMEM provides HRM scholars with a framework that connects algorithmic job design, worker interpretation, and motivational outcomes. Figure 1: Presents a visual representation of the framework and its three mechanisms.

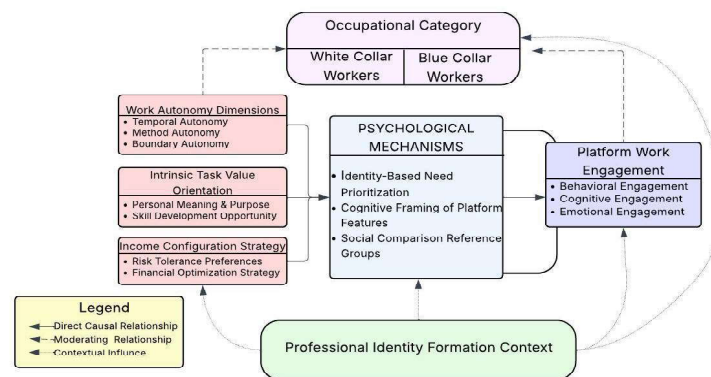


Fig. 1: The Occupational-Motivational Engagement Model (OMEM)

Source: Developed by the authors based on Self-Determination Theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000), Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory (Herzberg et al., 1959), the SMART work-design model (Parker & Knight, 2024),

and occupational identity research (Skorikov & Vondracek, 2011; Lips-Wiersma et al., 2016).

1. **Mechanism 1: Identity-Based Need Prioritisation:** Self-Determination Theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000) posits that autonomy, competence, and relatedness are universal psychological needs. Recent empirical research shows that these needs remain salient for platform workers even in the absence of traditional employment relationships. Fairness, recognition, and transparency are critical factors in fostering gig worker engagement (Lu et al., 2026; Nagre et al., 2025). OMEM extends this foundational insight by proposing those workers' occupational identities shape how these universal needs are prioritised and experienced in digital platform environments. Parker and Knight (2024) organise work characteristics into five categories in the SMART framework, each linked to distinct psychological mechanisms. The Autonomous category, for instance, covers timing control, method control, and decision-making autonomy. These dimensions map onto SDT's autonomy need but also reveal important subdimensions. OMEM proposes that occupational identity determines which subdimension becomes psychologically salient. For white-collar workers, method autonomy (control over how tasks are executed) tends to dominate. For blue-collar workers, timing autonomy (control over when work occurs) tends to take precedence. Both groups seek autonomy, but they emphasise different facets depending on occupational schemas.

A similar pattern holds for the SMART Mastery category (feedback, role clarity), which maps to SDT's competence need. Workers from different occupations define competence differently. White-collar workers often seek mastery through variety and complexity (the Stimulating category in Parker and Knight's terms). Blue-collar workers more often seek mastery through efficiency and consistency. The SMART Relational category connects to SDT's relatedness need, but occupational identity shapes which relational aspects matter most: professional recognition in one case, customer satisfaction in the other.

This occupationally based differentiation in need prioritisation echoes findings from lifespan job-design research, where Truxillo et al. (2012) show that worker age influences which job characteristics become most salient. Age-based differences reflect lifespan developmental processes. Occupational differences, by contrast, reflect identity-based schemas about what counts as meaningful work. Two platform workers of the same age but different occupational backgrounds (a freelance graphic designer and a delivery driver) will

prioritise different SMART categories and evaluate identical platform features differently based on their occupational identities, not their career stage.

Recent theoretical work emphasises that contemporary work-design research should take the social dimensions of work more seriously (Oldham & Hackman, 2010). Traditional job-design theory centred on task characteristics. Contemporary work, particularly in platform sectors, involves considerable social interaction and relationship management. Oldham and Hackman (2010) also note that the salience of particular work features varies across cultural contexts, and a parallel logic applies to occupational differences. Our framework extends this by proposing that occupational identity determines which social and motivational features of platform work become most salient.

For white-collar workers, occupational norms emphasise method autonomy, intellectual discretion, and professional mastery. These norms shape what they look for on a platform:

- Method autonomy, and particularly control over how tasks are executed (Parker and Knight's Autonomous-method dimension).
- Competence development through variety and complexity (the Stimulating category), linked to skill development, problem-solving, and opportunities for growth.
- Professional relatedness (the Relational category), often expressed through high-quality client interactions or constructive feedback that signals recognition of expertise.

Since their sense of identity is closely tied to expertise and meaningful contribution (Rosso et al., 2010; Lips-Wiersma et al., 2016), algorithmic constraints such as rigid task allocation or simplified rating systems may be experienced as threats to identity and to intrinsic motivation, even when other SMART categories are well designed.

For blue-collar workers, occupational identities are typically organised around efficiency, temporal autonomy, and performance-based competence. Their priorities follow accordingly:

- Temporal autonomy (the Autonomous-timing dimension), including flexible scheduling and predictable workflows that enable earnings optimisation.
- Competence through efficiency and consistency (Mastery), reinforced by immediate feedback and clear performance metrics.
- Customer-related relatedness (Relational), reflected in ratings, repeat clients, and service-quality cues that validate performance.

Structured workflows, transparent metrics, and algorithmic clarity may support their sense of competence and control, enhancing rather than constraining motivation (Wood et al., 2018), provided the Tolerable category is also maintained.

These occupationally rooted priorities shape what workers expect from platform features. Research shows that gig workers' expectations significantly influence their affective commitment and retention intentions (Kaur & Verma, 2025), which suggests that misalignment between occupational expectations and platform design is likely to produce engagement challenges. A white-collar platform worker entering with expectations of professional discretion may experience algorithmic task allocation as violating an identity-based need for method autonomy. A blue-collar worker expecting structured workflows may perceive the same system as supporting competence through clarity and predictability.

The broader point is that digital work environments can simultaneously support and undermine motivation depending on workers' occupationally rooted priorities. For HRM, the implication is straightforward. Algorithmic management systems and platform features must be tailored to occupational expectations if they are to avoid misalignment and unintended motivational consequences (Mainka et al., 2024). Table 1 summarises these differences.

Table 1: Occupational Differences in Need Prioritizations

Psychological Need	White-Collar Platform Workers	Blue-Collar Platform Workers
Autonomy	Method autonomy: control over task execution, approach selection, professional discretion.	Temporal autonomy: control over work timing, flexible scheduling, predictable workflows.
Competence	Growth through variety: skill development, challenging task, expertise advancement.	Efficiency and consistency: performance speed, clear standards, immediate feedback.
Relatedness	Professional recognition: quality client dialogue, collaborative problem-solving.	Customer satisfaction: positive ratings, repeat business, service-quality validation.

Based on Self-Determination Theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000), the SMART work-design model (Parker & Knight, 2024), and occupational identity research (Skorikov & Vondracek, 2011; Lips-Wiersma et al., 2016).

2. Mechanism: Cognitive Framing of Digital Platform Features

Workers interpret digital platform features (algorithmic control, task allocation, ratings, and workflow structures) through occupationally shaped cognitive frames. Cognitive framing theory (Kahneman & Tversky, 1984) holds that individuals rely on mental schemas to make sense of complex or ambiguous environments. In digital labour, where performance information and coordination are mediated by technology, these schemas strongly influence motivational outcomes.

The SMART framework (Parker & Knight, 2024) proposes that work characteristics link to psychological outcomes through universal mechanisms: stimulating work produces meaningfulness, autonomous work reduces strain, relational work satisfies relatedness needs. OMEM adds a qualification. Occupational identity shapes how these linkages actually operate. The same algorithmic feature that enhances one SMART dimension may be read as diminishing another, depending on occupational schemas.

For white-collar workers, occupational schemas emphasise autonomy, judgment, and creativity. Platform features are typically framed as follows:

- Algorithmic task allocation is read as limiting discretion (Autonomous-method) and reducing opportunities for professional judgment, even where it enhances efficiency.
- Performance monitoring is interpreted as intrusive surveillance that undermines the Autonomous category and violates expectations of trust and expertise.
- Ratings and simplified metrics are viewed as inadequate representations of complex, knowledge-intensive work, and as failing to capture the Stimulating and Mastery dimensions they value.
- Structured workflows are framed as de-skilling routines that limit the Stimulating category by reducing problem-solving opportunities.

These frames align with research showing that professionals often

see algorithmic systems as undervaluing nuance, skill, and professional contribution (Bellesia et al., 2022; Wood et al., 2018; Duggan et al., 2023). Algorithmic controls may therefore undermine intrinsic motivation by clashing with expectations of professional autonomy, even where other SMART categories are well designed.

For blue-collar workers, occupational schemas emphasise efficiency, predictability, and clear performance indicators. The framing shifts accordingly:

- Algorithmic allocation is read as a tool that enhances efficiency and streamlines workflow, supporting the Autonomous-timing dimension by reducing uncertainty about task access.
- Monitoring tools are interpreted as useful performance cues (Mastery-feedback) rather than threats, since they provide clarity about standards.
- Ratings systems are perceived as fair, transparent, and informative indicators of service quality, and as valuable Mastery feedback that reinforces competence.
- Structured workflows are viewed as clarity-enhancing guidelines that support the Tolerable category and establish clear role expectations.

These interpretations are consistent with studies showing that blue-collar workers often value algorithmic clarity and structured task flows that reinforce competence and predictability (Möhlmann et al., 2021; Lehdonvirta, 2018). Such framing strengthens motivation by enhancing feelings of efficiency and control within the work-design structure.

From an HRM standpoint, the practical upshot is the need for occupationally informed algorithmic design. Systems built to promote fairness or improve consistency for one occupational group may be perceived as restricting autonomy or diminishing identity for another (Mainka et al., 2024). Managing perceptions of justice, transparency, and autonomy in digitally mediated work therefore requires more than universal design principles.

Table 2: Occupational Differences in Cognitive Framing of Algorithmic Platform Features

Platform Feature	White-Collar Framing	Blue-Collar Framing
Algorithmic task allocation	Limits professional discretion and judgment; reduces work-selection control.	Enhances efficiency; streamlines access to earning opportunities.
Performance monitoring	Intrusive surveillance undermining trust and autonomy.	Useful feedback; transparent accountability.
Rating systems	Inadequate proxies for complex work; commodifies expertise.	Fair, objective service-quality indicators.
Structured workflows	De-skilling routines limiting creativity.	Clarity-enhancing guidelines supporting consistent performance.

Framing patterns derived from cognitive framing theory (Kahneman & Tversky, 1984), SMART work-design categories (Parker & Knight, 2024), and empirical research on occupational differences in platform work (Bellesia et al., 2022; Wood et al., 2018; Lehdonvirta, 2018; Möhlmann et al., 2021).

3. Mechanism: Social Comparison Reference Groups Social comparison theory has become increasingly central to understanding organisational behaviour (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024). Matthews and Kelemen (2024) show that comparisons are intensified in organisational contexts by competitive dynamics, scarce resources, accessible performance data, and prolonged interaction. These conditions are amplified in digital platform work, where algorithmic systems render performance metrics continuously visible and workers operate in competitive markets for tasks, clients, and ratings.

Contemporary scholarship distinguishes three comparison dimensions: compensation, capabilities, and social dynamics (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024). Workers do not respond uniformly. Different occupational groups emphasise different dimensions and select different targets. Matthews and Kelemen (2024) further distinguish between comparison targets (who workers compare with) and comparison dimensions (what

workers compare on). In platform work, occupational identity shapes both target selection and dimension salience.

For white-collar workers, comparisons typically centre on career advancement, expertise, and professional identity. Social-dynamics comparisons are dominant, focused on client portfolio prestige, project complexity, and qualitative feedback signalling professional recognition. Typical comparison points include:

- Complexity or prestige of client portfolios.
- Skill development opportunities in assigned tasks.
- Platform visibility and access to high-value opportunities.
- Qualitative feedback signalling professional recognition.

Positive comparisons tend to reinforce identity alignment with professional standards. Unfavourable comparisons can undermine perceived competence and identity coherence (Ibarra, 1999; Pratt et al., 2006).

For blue-collar workers, comparisons revolve around efficiency, earnings, and customer satisfaction. Capability comparisons built on efficiency metrics, completion rates, and customer-satisfaction scores take precedence. Typical comparison points include:

- Daily or weekly earnings.
- Task completion rates and speed.
- Customer ratings and repeat-client frequency.
- Route efficiency or algorithmic matching outcomes.

These comparisons shape perceptions of fairness and performance adequacy. Upward comparisons can motivate increased effort, while persistent unfavourable comparisons tend to diminish engagement (Churchill & Craig, 2019; Wood et al., 2018).

Matthews and Kelemen (2024) distinguish between atomistic comparisons (objective numerical differences) and molecular comparisons (workers' subjective interpretations of those differences). Platform algorithms generate abundant atomistic data — precise earnings, completion times, ratings — so objective differences are continuously visible. The motivational impact, however, depends on the molecular interpretations that run through occupational schemas (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024). A substantial weekly earnings gap may be interpreted as an efficiency deficit requiring improved performance (a characteristically blue-collar framing), or as evidence of differential access to high-value clients (a characteristically white-collar framing). The atomistic data is the same; the motivational response is not.

Matthews and Kelemen (2024) also note that comparison motivation varies by occupational context. White-collar workers

whose identities rest on unique expertise may be less motivated to engage with standardised-metric comparisons, since such information is perceived as inadequate for evaluating professional worth. Blue-collar workers whose identities are tied to efficiency may engage more readily with comparative metrics that benchmark their productivity and service quality.

Digital platforms heighten comparison salience by embedding performance cues directly into interfaces. These comparison processes influence identity construction, meaning-making, and motivational orientation (Rosso et al., 2010). For HRM, recognising these occupationally distinct patterns is essential for designing performance systems that minimise harmful comparison pressure while supporting motivation and wellbeing. Table 3 summarises comparison dimensions and target selection patterns by occupation.

Table 3: Social comparison dimensions and target selection by occupation

Comparison Aspect	White-Collar Workers	Blue-Collar Workers
Primary dimensions	Social dynamics: client prestige, project complexity, professional recognition.	Capabilities: efficiency, completion rates, performance consistency.
Target selection	Professional similarity: comparable expertise and skill level.	Operational similarity: similar task types and experience.
Information type	Molecular: subjective interpretation of quality and career progress.	Atomistic: objective performance differences and quantifiable metrics.
Upward comparison response	Assimilative (learning) when access is fair; contrastive (envy) when blocked.	Assimilative (motivation) when gap attributed to effort; contrastive when gaps persist.
Identity impact	Reinforces or threatens professional identity coherence.	Reinforces or threatens performance-based competence.

Framework integrates Festinger's (1954) social comparison theory with the contemporary organisational framework of Matthews and Kelemen (2024) and the SMART work-design categories (Parker & Knight, 2024), distinguishing between comparison targets, dimensions, and interpretation processes (atomistic vs. molecular).

5. THEORETICAL SYNTHESIS: INTEGRATED PROPOSITIONS

Drawing on the three mechanisms, this section sets out seven propositions that connect occupational-identity dynamics with motivational responses in digital platform work. The propositions are designed to be empirically testable and to provide a foundation for future HRM research.

Proposition 1. Occupational identity moderates the relationship between algorithmic control and perceived autonomy. White-collar workers perceive algorithmic control as limiting method autonomy (the Autonomous-method dimension in Parker and Knight's terms). Blue-collar workers perceive it as supporting temporal autonomy and workflow efficiency (the Autonomous-timing dimension).

Proposition 2. Occupational identity moderates the influence of platform-based feedback on perceived competence. White-collar workers interpret simplified ratings as insufficient indicators of competence, an inadequate Mastery signal for complex work. Blue-collar workers view them as reinforcing efficiency and performance-based skill, an appropriate Mastery signal for operational work.

Proposition 3. Task structure has differential effects on intrinsic motivation across occupational groups. Structured, routinised task flows undermine intrinsic motivation for white-collar workers by reducing Stimulating work characteristics (variety, problem-solving). For blue-collar workers, the same structures enhance intrinsic motivation by reinforcing Mastery (role clarity) and Tolerable (predictability) characteristics.

Proposition 4. Workers' cognitive framing of digital platform features explains occupational differences in perceived fairness. White-collar workers frame algorithmic decisions as less fair because they reduce discretion on valued SMART dimensions (Autonomous-method, Stimulating variety). Blue-collar workers frame them as more fair because they enhance consistency and transparency on valued dimensions (Autonomous-timing, Mastery clarity).

Proposition 5. Social comparison processes influence motivational outcomes differently across occupational groups, through both comparison target selection and comparison dimension emphasis. White-collar workers select comparison targets based on professional similarity and compare on dimensions related to skill development, client prestige, and portfolio complexity (Stimulating and Relational

SMART categories). Blue-collar workers select comparison targets based on operational similarity and compare on dimensions related to earnings consistency, task completion efficiency, and customer ratings (Mastery feedback). These occupationally distinct comparison patterns, operating simultaneously on target and dimension selection (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024), produce differential effects on intrinsic motivation, job satisfaction, and identity coherence.

Proposition 5b. The relationship between objective performance differences (atomistic comparisons) and motivational outcomes is mediated by workers' subjective interpretations (molecular comparisons), with occupational identity moderating this mediation. Identical objective performance gaps produce different motivational responses depending on whether workers interpret those gaps through white-collar schemas (emphasising access, opportunity, or systemic factors affecting Stimulating and Relational work quality) or blue-collar schemas (emphasising effort, efficiency, or skill-development needs affecting Mastery and capability dimensions).

Proposition 6. Occupational identity moderates how reputation systems shape identity development in digital platform work. Reputation cues strengthen professional identity for white-collar workers, signalling expertise and Relational standing. For blue-collar workers, the same cues strengthen economic or performance-based identity, signalling Mastery and efficiency.

Proposition 7. Engagement and retention outcomes vary by occupation because of differences in need prioritisation, cognitive framing, and social-comparison dynamics. Research already shows that gig-worker commitment influences retention intentions (Kaur & Verma, 2025) and that employer branding factors such as fairness and recognition foster engagement (Lu et al., 2026; Nagre et al., 2025). OMEM adds a qualification: the pathways to these outcomes differ by occupational identity. White-collar workers show higher engagement when afforded method autonomy and meaningful work. Blue-collar workers show higher engagement when given predictable structures and feedback-rich workflows.

Table 4. OMEM research propositions and theoretical grounding

Proposition	Core prediction	Mechanism
P1	Occupational identity moderates algorithmic control effects on autonomy.	Identity-based need prioritisation
P2	Occupational identity moderates platform feedback effects on competence.	Identity-based need prioritisation
P3	Task structure differentially affects intrinsic motivation by occupation.	Need prioritisation and cognitive framing
P4	Cognitive framing explains occupational differences in perceived fairness.	Cognitive framing
P5	Social comparison processes differ by occupation through target and dimension selection.	Social comparison processes
P5b	Molecular interpretations mediate atomistic comparison effects, moderated by occupation.	Social comparison processes
P6	Reputation systems shape identity development differently by occupation.	Social comparison and need prioritisation
P7	Engagement and retention vary by occupation through combined mechanisms.	All three mechanisms

6. IMPLICATIONS FOR HRM AND JOB DESIGN

OMEM carries several implications for HRM as organisations and platforms increasingly rely on algorithmic systems to structure work. Because occupational identity shapes how workers interpret autonomy, competence, relatedness, and fairness in digital environments, HRM practices need to be designed with occupational nuance in mind.

Occupationally Sensitive Job and Work Design

Digital labour systems should be tailored to the motivational profiles of different occupational groups. For white-collar workers, who prioritise method autonomy and professional development, HRM should emphasise flexible task execution, opportunities for creativity, and access to complex or growth-oriented assignments. For blue-collar workers, effective job design should centre on predictable workflows, transparent metrics, and performance indicators that reinforce competence and efficiency (Mainka et al., 2024).

Algorithmic HRM Design and Governance

Platform-based employer branding and HRM practices play a critical role in fostering gig worker engagement even where traditional employment contracts are absent (Lu et al., 2026; Nagre et al., 2025). Engagement strategies, however, need to account for occupational differences in need prioritisation and cognitive framing. Fairness, recognition, and transparency generally enhance gig worker satisfaction, but OMEM suggests these factors are interpreted differently across occupational categories. Recognition may manifest as public acknowledgement of expertise for white-collar workers, but as performance-based bonuses for blue-collar workers. Fairness may centre on equitable access to complex projects for one group, and on transparent task-allocation algorithms for the other.

Algorithmic management systems must take occupational schemas into account. White-collar workers often expect explainability, discretion, and feedback-rich systems that respect expert judgment. Blue-collar workers typically respond more positively to precise allocation logic, real-time feedback, and minimised uncertainty. HRM should ensure that algorithmic systems allow for transparency, appeal pathways, and customisable features that can accommodate these occupational preferences (Duggan et al., 2023).

Supporting Early-Career Identity Formation

As digital platforms become early-career entry points, HRM should incorporate development-oriented features such as mentoring tools, skill dashboards, and guided exploration of task types. These can help workers form stable professional identities in contexts that lack traditional socialisation structures.

Tailored Feedback and Evaluation Systems

Since occupational groups interpret ratings differently, HRM should design evaluation systems that match workers' identity needs. White-collar workers tend to need richer, qualitative feedback linked to learning. Blue-collar workers tend to benefit more from clear, quantitative metrics that enhance feelings of competence.

Managing Social-Comparison Dynamics and Wellbeing

Platform visibility of ratings, earnings, and performance can intensify comparison-based pressure. Matthews and Kelemen (2024) show that comparisons produce both constructive outcomes (motivation, identity validation) and destructive ones (envy, demotivation), with effects varying by occupational context.

For white-collar workers, harmful comparisons tend to arise when systems emphasise efficiency metrics that are perceived as inadequate representations of professional capability (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024). HRM can mitigate these effects by diversifying the visible indicators of success and allowing workers to customise the comparison dimensions they see.

For blue-collar workers, harmful comparisons tend to emerge from perceptions of unfair allocation or unexplained rating variations (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024). HRM can address these concerns by ensuring algorithmic transparency, stabilising performance expectations, and providing explainable feedback.

The common thread is that HRM systems designed without occupational nuance risk undermining motivation, fairness perceptions, and wellbeing. Occupationally sensitive design is therefore essential for effective algorithmic HRM. Table 5 sets out specific design principles.

Table 5. Occupationally sensitive algorithmic HRM design principles

HRM system element	White-collar design principles	Blue-collar design principles
Task allocation	Provide project choice; emphasise growth opportunities.	Optimise efficiency; provide transparent matching logic.
Performance feedback	Provide rich qualitative feedback; emphasise skill development.	Provide clear quantitative metrics; emphasise consistency.
Autonomy support	Maximise method autonomy; allow approach customisation.	Maximise temporal autonomy; enable schedule flexibility.
Evaluation systems	Use multidimensional assessment; capture expertise and quality.	Use transparent standardised metrics; capture speed and reliability.
Development support	Offer skill badges and complex project access.	Provide efficiency tips and performance benchmarking.
Comparison display	Allow customisation of visible dimensions; highlight quality.	Emphasise performance metrics; highlight personal progress.
Comparison management	Diversify success indicators; provide varied developmental trajectories.	Ensure fair allocation transparency; stabilise earning expectations.

Derived from OMEM mechanisms and supported by the SMART work-design framework (Parker & Knight, 2024), algorithmic HRM research (Duggan et al., 2023; Mainka et al., 2024), platform work studies (Jarrahi et al., 2020; Möhlmann et al., 2021), and social comparison theory in organisational settings (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024).

7. THEORETICAL CONTRIBUTIONS

OMEM makes several contributions to HRM, occupational psychology, and digital-labour research. The central contribution is to show how occupational identity interacts with algorithmic systems to shape workers' motivational experiences in digital platform work.

Contribution to HRM Theory and Motivation Research

OMEM contributes to HRM theory by positioning occupational identity as a central moderator that shapes how workers prioritise autonomy, competence, and relatedness in technology-mediated contexts (Gagné et al., 2022). This responds to a gap flagged by Boon et al. (2019): the lack of theoretical clarity around how individual characteristics moderate HR practice effectiveness. OMEM offers a mechanism-based explanation for why different occupational groups respond differently to the same platform features, and so helps to account for heterogeneous motivational responses observed among platform workers.

Contribution to Job Design and Algorithmic HRM

OMEM challenges the traditional assumption of uniform worker interpretations by showing how algorithmic affordances interact with occupational schemas to produce different motivational outcomes. Occupational identity, a social-identity construct, functions as a powerful moderator of platform-design features (Oldham & Hackman, 2010; Truxillo et al., 2012). This extends job-design and algorithmic-HRM literature by surfacing occupationally contingent interpretations of fairness, control, and competence (Duggan et al., 2023; Kadolkar et al., 2024; Wood et al., 2018; Mainka et al., 2024).

Contribution to Occupational Identity and Career-Development Research

OMEM extends occupational-identity literature (Ibarra, 1999; Pratt et al., 2006; Reissner & Armitage-Chan, 2024) by theorising identity development in digital contexts, where algorithmic cues, online communities, and performance dashboards substitute for traditional developmental structures.

Contribution to Digital-Labour and Gig-Work Scholarship

OMEM builds on digital-labour literature (Jarrahi et al., 2020; Möhlmann et al., 2021; Lu et al., 2026) by clarifying how occupational

schemas shape cognitive framing and social-comparison processes. It also extends the comprehensive framework of social-comparison theory (Matthews & Kelemen, 2024) to digital platform contexts, showing how occupational identity moderates both comparison target selection and comparison dimension emphasis. The result is a more nuanced, identity-driven explanation for differentiated engagement, satisfaction, and retention outcomes across platform occupational categories.

8. LIMITATIONS

Several limitations should be acknowledged.

First, the binary white-collar / blue-collar categorisation, while theoretically grounded and empirically useful, simplifies the complexity of platform work. Many platform roles blend professional and operational elements (professional photography services, technical home repairs), producing hybrid occupational identities that do not sit neatly in either category. Future research should examine how workers with hybrid occupational identities navigate platform work, and whether they exhibit motivational patterns that combine elements from both categories or represent distinct third patterns.

Second, OMEM focuses on occupational identity as the primary moderator of motivational processes, but other individual differences (career stage, financial dependency, cultural background, prior work experience) are also likely to shape platform-work experiences. The model acknowledges that occupational identity becomes particularly salient during early-career stages, but it does not fully develop how these moderating effects may vary across career stages, or how financial necessity might override occupational identity effects. Further research on boundary conditions and additional moderators is needed.

Age-related factors may also interact with occupational identity to shape platform-work experiences. Truxillo et al. (2012) show that worker age systematically moderates job-design effects through lifespan development processes. In platform contexts, a young white-collar worker early in their career may prioritise different features than an older white-collar worker approaching retirement, even though both share occupational identity. Future work should test whether age and occupational identity operate independently, additively, or synergistically in shaping platform-work motivation.

Third, while OMEM treats occupational identity as shaping social-comparison processes, the framework does not fully engage the complexity of comparison dynamics in multi-dimensional platform

environments. Matthews and Kelemen (2024) show that organisational comparisons operate across multiple dimensions simultaneously (compensation, capabilities, social dynamics) and involve both target selection and dimension weighting. Platform workers may engage in upward comparisons on some dimensions and downward comparisons on others, producing ambivalent motivational states. Future research should examine how workers navigate multi-dimensional comparison environments, and whether occupational identity provides protective framing for potentially demotivating comparative information.

Fourth, this paper draws primarily on Western (largely North American and European) research contexts. Cultural norms significantly shape both occupational-identity formation and motivational priorities. How occupational schemas develop and influence platform-work motivation in collectivist cultures, developing economies, or regions with different labour-market structures remains an open question. The proposed mechanisms may operate differently across cultural contexts and require cross-cultural validation.

Fifth, OMEM does not extensively address power dynamics, exploitation, or the structural inequalities built into platform-work arrangements. While the model explains why workers interpret platform features differently, it does not engage deeply with critiques of platform capitalism or with the precarity experienced by many platform workers. The framework could be extended to examine how occupational identity interacts with power asymmetries to shape not only motivation but also resistance, collective action, and worker advocacy.

Sixth, the model treats occupational identity as relatively stable within individuals, yet platform work itself may reshape occupational identity over time. Workers may enter platforms with clear occupational identities that then evolve, fragment, or transform through platform experiences. Longitudinal research is needed to examine identity-change processes and their bidirectional relationships with motivational outcomes.

Finally, the paper concentrates on motivation as the primary outcome, but digital platform work also affects wellbeing, skill development, career progression, and economic security. Future work should examine how the proposed mechanisms influence these broader outcomes, and whether occupational identity moderates these relationships as well.

9. FUTURE RESEARCH AGENDA

OMEM opens several promising directions for future research across HRM, occupational psychology, and digital-labour scholarship. As work continues to shift toward technology-mediated contexts, empirical inquiry is needed to validate and extend the propositions set out here.

Empirical Examination of Occupational Moderators

Future research should test empirically how occupational identity moderates motivational responses to algorithmic control, autonomy, and feedback. Multi-group structural equation modelling can compare motivational pathways across white-collar, blue-collar, and hybrid occupations, providing a way to assess the robustness of the proposed mechanisms. Studies could examine how occupational identity moderates the relationships between the SMART work-design categories (Parker & Knight, 2024) and motivational outcomes, testing whether the same work characteristics produce different effects based on occupational schemas.

Such designs could also incorporate age as an additional moderator, testing whether occupational identity and lifespan development processes (Truxillo et al., 2012) operate independently, additively, or interactively. For instance, studies could examine whether the occupational-identity effects proposed by OMEM hold constant across age groups, or whether young white-collar workers show different motivational patterns than older white-collar workers due to combined effects of occupational schemas and career-stage considerations.

Specific research questions informed by Matthews and Kelemen (2024) include: (1) How do white-collar and blue-collar platform workers differ in their selection of comparison targets (similar others, top performers, personal historical performance)? (2) Which comparison dimensions (compensation, capabilities, social dynamics) are most salient to workers in different occupational categories? (3) How do molecular comparison processes mediate the relationship between atomistic comparison data and motivational outcomes? (4) Under what conditions do upward comparisons produce assimilative responses (motivation, learning) rather than contrastive ones (envy, disengagement) across occupational groups?

Matthews and Kelemen (2024) also note that most social-comparison research in organisational settings has focused on micro-

level (individual) processes, with limited attention to meso-level (team or group) comparisons. Platform-work research could extend this by examining how occupational communities within platforms engage in collective comparisons with other occupational groups, possibly producing identity-protective framing or collective-action responses to perceived inequities in algorithmic allocation or compensation structures.

Experiments on Algorithmic HRM Design and Fairness

Experimental and quasi-experimental designs could manipulate elements of algorithmic management, such as transparency, explainability, or task-allocation logic, to examine their effects on perceived fairness, autonomy, and competence across occupational groups (Gagné et al., 2022). Such designs would clarify which algorithmic features support or hinder motivation across different occupational groups, and how these effects map onto the SMART work-design categories. Experimental studies could test whether increasing Autonomous-method control benefits white-collar workers while increasing Autonomous-timing control benefits blue-collar workers, or whether enhancing Mastery feedback quality differentially affects occupational groups based on feedback complexity versus clarity.

Longitudinal Studies of Identity Development

Because identity formation unfolds over time, longitudinal research is needed to track how workers construct and adjust their professional identities in digital-labour environments. Combining digital trace data with repeated survey measures could provide insight into how identity-based need prioritisation evolves as workers gain experience (Van Zoonen et al., 2023). Such studies could examine whether platform experiences reshape occupational identities over time, creating feedback loops between work-design exposure across SMART categories, identity development, and motivational outcomes.

Cross-Occupational and Cross-Cultural Comparisons

Masta and Kaushiva's (2024) systematic review noted that platform-work research has so far focused primarily on service providers in developed markets. OMEM is designed to travel across diverse gig-worker profiles (service, goods, data providers) and geographic contexts. Future research should test empirically whether the occupational-identity mechanisms proposed here operate similarly in emerging markets, where platform work is expanding rapidly

(Government of India, 2026; Nagre et al., 2025), and across different platform sectors. Recent research has examined commitment and retention among gig workers (Kaur & Verma, 2025; Lu et al., 2026); future studies should investigate whether the antecedents of commitment differ across occupational groups. OMEM predicts that white-collar workers develop commitment through professional-development opportunities and meaningful work, whereas blue-collar workers develop commitment through earnings stability and performance-based recognition.

Digital platforms operate globally, but cultural norms shape how occupational identity and motivational priorities are expressed. Comparative studies could investigate how cultural contexts interact with occupational schemas to influence perceptions of fairness, competence, and autonomy. Oldham and Hackman (2010) observe that the salience of particular work features varies across cultural contexts, suggesting that cultural and occupational factors may jointly moderate responses to the SMART work-design categories in platform contexts. Research that integrates occupation, age, and culture as simultaneous moderators would provide a more comprehensive picture of job-design heterogeneity.

Qualitative Studies on Worker Sense-Making

Qualitative research, including interviews, ethnographies, and diary studies, can deepen understanding of how workers interpret algorithmic signals, evaluate feedback systems, and negotiate occupational expectations. Such studies can provide granular insight into identity work and meaning-making in technology-mediated environments (Petriglieri et al., 2018). Qualitative methods could explore how workers describe their prioritisation of different SMART work-design categories, how they frame algorithmic interventions, and how they select comparison targets and dimensions in their everyday work.

Taken collectively, these directions offer pathways for empirically testing OMEM and for expanding knowledge about identity, motivation, and worker experiences in emerging forms of digital labour.

10. CONCLUSION

Digital platforms are transforming how work is organised, supervised, and experienced. This paper has developed the Occupational-Motivational Engagement Model (OMEM) to explain

how occupational identity moderates motivational experiences in algorithmically managed work environments. Integrating Self-Determination Theory, Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory, and occupational-identity scholarship, OMEM identifies three psychological mechanisms — identity-based need prioritisation, cognitive framing of platform features, and occupation-specific social-comparison processes — that together help explain why workers from different occupational backgrounds experience digital platform work in fundamentally different ways.

OMEM extends contemporary work-design theory by showing how occupational identity shapes workers' interpretations of algorithmic job characteristics. The SMART framework (Parker & Knight, 2024) identifies five universal categories of work-design characteristics that link to motivational outcomes through distinct psychological mechanisms. OMEM complements this framework by treating occupational identity as a moderator that determines which SMART categories workers prioritise, how workers cognitively frame algorithmic implementations of those categories, and which performance dimensions workers emphasise in social-comparison processes. Where SMART establishes what work characteristics matter universally, OMEM explains why and how they matter differently across occupational groups.

These insights respond to a gap highlighted by recent systematic reviews of platform work (Kadolkar et al., 2024; Masta & Kaushiva, 2024), which documented limited comparative research on how different worker profiles experience platform structures. Recent empirical work shows that algorithmic reliability and employer branding influence gig-worker engagement (Lu et al., 2026; Nagre et al., 2025) and that worker commitment affects platform retention (Kaur & Verma, 2025). OMEM provides the theoretical foundation for understanding why and how these relationships differ by occupational identity. This mechanism-based explanation advances HRM scholarship by connecting algorithmic job design, occupational schemas, and motivational outcomes in technology-mediated work environments.

For HRM practitioners, the main takeaway is the importance of occupationally sensitive design in algorithmic management systems. Algorithmic HRM practices intended to enhance fairness, efficiency, or consistency may support motivation for some occupational groups while undermining it for others. White-collar workers typically need method autonomy, professional discretion, and qualitative feedback

that recognises expertise. Blue-collar workers typically benefit from temporal autonomy, transparent performance metrics, and structured workflows that reinforce competence through clarity. Recognising these occupationally grounded expectations is essential as organisations increasingly rely on digital platforms to coordinate work, evaluate performance, and shape worker experiences.

As Oldham and Hackman (2010) observed, work is increasingly organised not as fixed jobs but as fluid arrangements across organisational boundaries. Platform work represents the most extreme expression of this shift, where workers simultaneously navigate algorithmic management systems, manage relationships with multiple clients, and construct their own work arrangements. In these contexts, occupational identity becomes the critical organising framework through which workers make sense of, and respond to, platform-design features. As digital labour continues to expand across sectors and geographies, with 12 million workers in India alone as of FY2024–25 (Government of India, 2026), OMEM provides a timely foundation for understanding worker heterogeneity and for guiding the development of more inclusive, motivating, and occupationally sensitive digital work systems.

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